cyera

Off the Path

Where the game is today, and where I think it should go.

Every screen, side by side. The left of each slide is the build as it ran on 18 October, captured from the game itself. The right is the proposal. Underneath, what it would take.

There is a question for you on the last slide.

Cyera Research · 18 October 2026

Further along than it looks

The errand, the basket, the scoring, the reveal at the end and the hidden text in every skill card are all built and all correct. Most of what follows is presentation, not logic.

Eleven screens with a gap

Six are small changes. Four are medium. One is a screen we have never built. None of them changes what the game is about.

Two I would fix anyway

On a phone there is no way out of a skill card except a choice you cannot undo. And the one honest skill in the game can be spotted without reading it, because its card is shorter than the others.

A NOTE ON THE PICTURES

The left-hand screenshots are the real build, driven to each screen through the game's own logic. The right-hand frames use the approved concept art, which the build does not render yet.

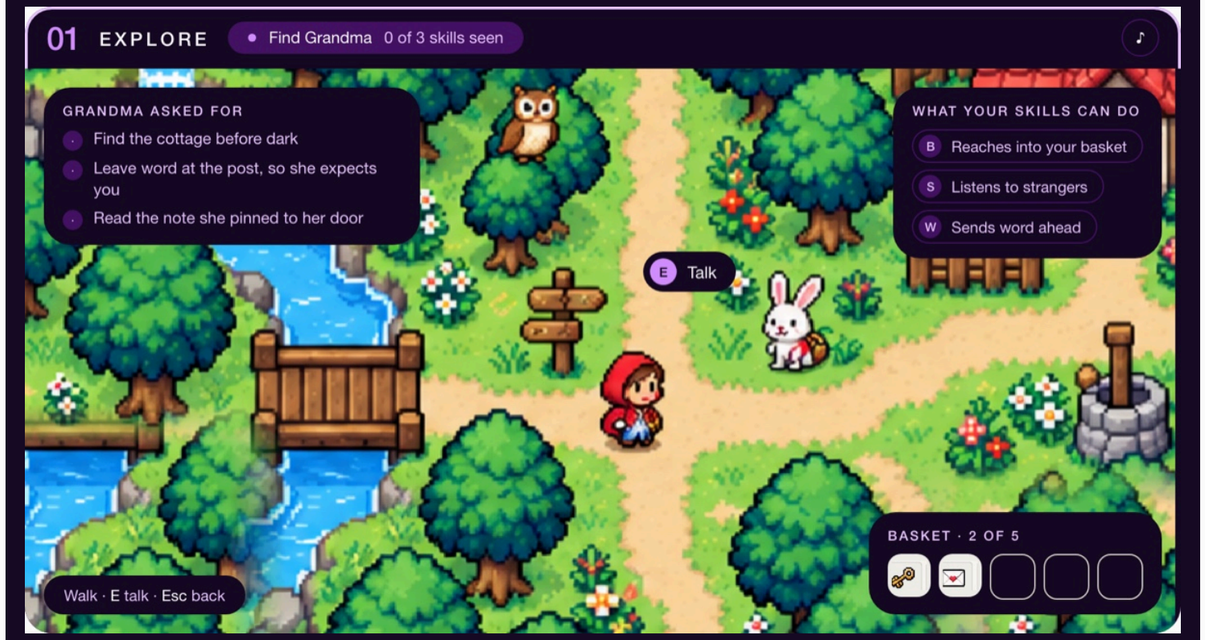
THE ART Same game, same camera, two generations apart. This is the one thing here that is not a code change.

WHAT THE GAME DRAWS TODAY



- Placeholder art we generated ourselves, so the game could be played while the design was settled. Call it the 1990s version.
- It is readable, it is on brand, and it is plainly a placeholder.

THE SAME FOREST, REMASTERED



- The approved concept board, assembled into a playable-width frame: the whole panel, with the touch controls painted out.
- Measured, it is drawn at two and a half times the game's pixel scale, so it cannot be dropped in. It has to be redrawn as tiles and characters at the game's own size.
- It covers about seventy per cent of a screen, and seven of the characters were never drawn.

WHAT IT TAKES A commission rather than a sprint, and the longest lead time of anything in this deck. The next seven slides walk the map and show the difference place by place.

THE START, AND THE SIGNPOST

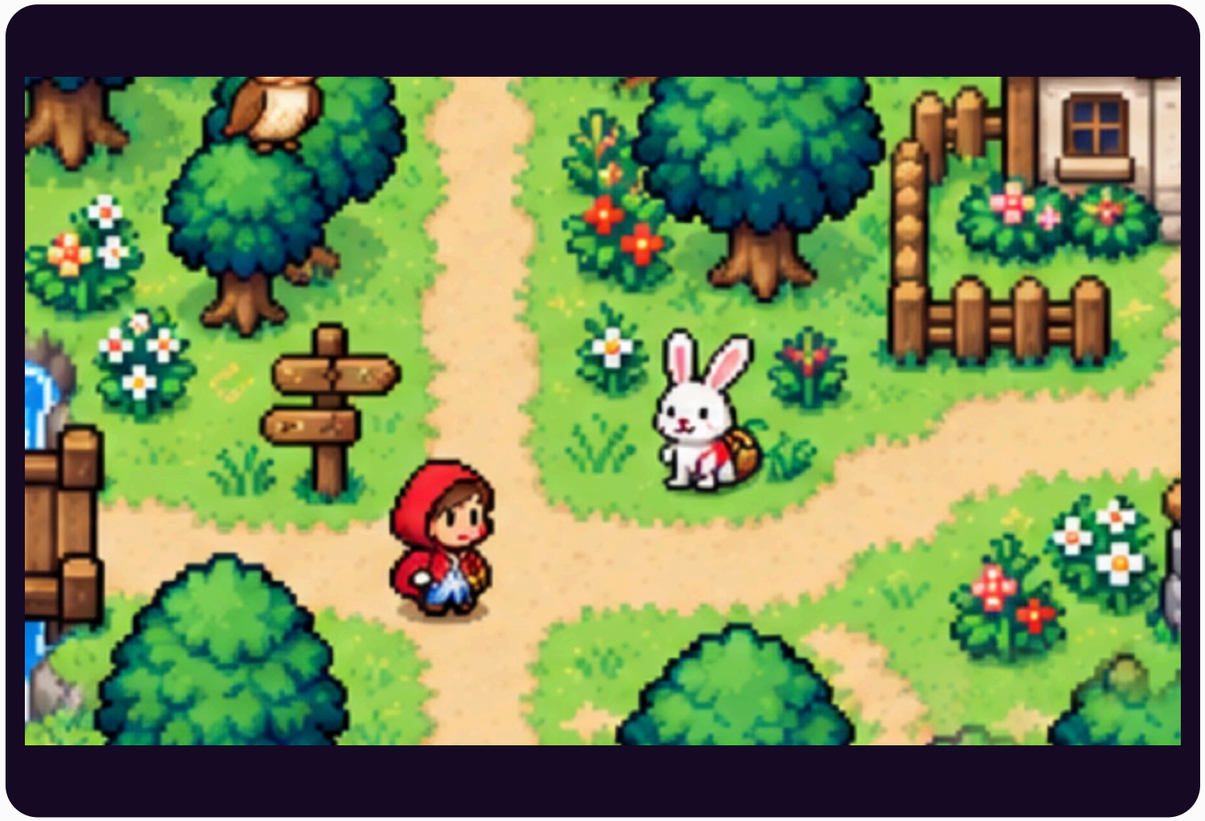
Where every player begins.

WHAT IT LOOKS LIKE NOW



- Flat grass, a plank for a bridge, and a signpost too small to read.
- Everything sits on one plane. Nothing is in front of anything else.

WHAT IT WOULD LOOK LIKE



- The same junction with depth: verges, planting, a path that bends.
- The signpost reads as carved wood with two arms.

SAME PLACE, SAME CAMERA

Left is a screenshot of the game as it runs today, taken by walking to this spot. Right is the approved art for the same place.

THE RABBIT'S STALL

The first offer in the game is made here.

WHAT IT LOOKS LIKE NOW



- The stall is a striped awning on four legs, with nothing on it.
- You cannot tell what is being sold.

WHAT IT WOULD LOOK LIKE



- A market stall with goods laid out: compasses, barrels, a painted sign.
- A lantern on a post beside it. You can see what he is offering before he says a word.

SAME PLACE, SAME CAMERA — Left is a screenshot of the game as it runs today, taken by walking to this spot. Right is the approved art for the same place.

THE OWL'S TREE AND THE FOUNTAIN

The supply chain beat, and the prettiest corner of the map.

WHAT IT LOOKS LIKE NOW



- The owl is a small bird standing on flat ground.
- The fountain is three pixels of blue.

WHAT IT WOULD LOOK LIKE



- The owl sits in the canopy of a real tree, above the river.
- A waterfall feeds the stream, and the stream runs under a bridge.

SAME PLACE, SAME CAMERA Left is a screenshot of the game as it runs today, taken by walking to this spot. Right is the approved art for the same place.

THE WELL — Where the Magpie keeps her tally.

WHAT IT LOOKS LIKE NOW



- A grey ring on the grass, beside a brown rectangle for a bridge.
- Readable, and nothing more.

WHAT IT WOULD LOOK LIKE



- Stone courses, a winding post, flowers at the foot.
- The cottage fence and gate are visible behind it, so you can see where you are going.

SAME PLACE, SAME CAMERA — Left is a screenshot of the game as it runs today, taken by walking to this spot. Right is the approved art for the same place.

THE LANTERN POST

The third traveller waits here.

WHAT IT LOOKS LIKE NOW



- A yellow dash on a pole. The keeper is a purple shape.
- This is the character the concept board never drew.

WHAT IT WOULD LOOK LIKE



- A hanging lantern with lit glass and a stone footing.
- The bridge and the river behind, and the stall further along the path.

SAME PLACE, SAME CAMERA

Left is a screenshot of the game as it runs today, taken by walking to this spot. Right is the approved art for the same place.

THE GATE, AND THE MAILBOX

The last stretch before the door.

WHAT IT LOOKS LIKE NOW



- The fence is a row of brown lines with a gap in it.
- The cottage is a beige block at the edge of the frame.

WHAT IT WOULD LOOK LIKE



- A picket fence with posts and rails, and a mailbox with the flag up.
- Paw prints in the earth, which are the whole ending in one detail.

SAME PLACE, SAME CAMERA Left is a screenshot of the game as it runs today, taken by walking to this spot. Right is the approved art for the same place.

GRANDMA'S DOOR

Where the game ends.

WHAT IT LOOKS LIKE NOW



- A beige box with a red roof and two windows.
- Nothing in the window. Nothing on the step.

WHAT IT WOULD LOOK LIKE



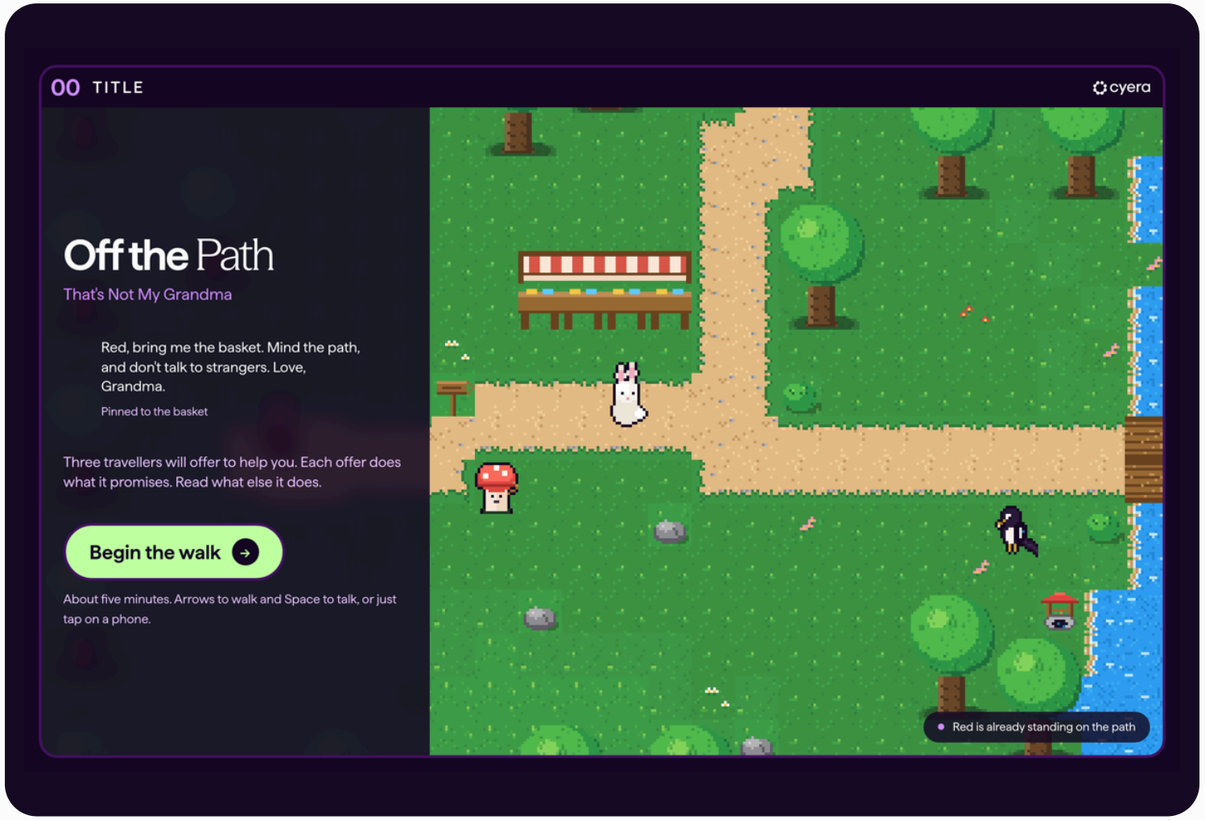
- Tiles on the roof, a stone surround, ivy, a woodpile.
- A lit window with a shape in it, which is the reveal the whole walk is built towards.

SAME PLACE, SAME CAMERA Left is a screenshot of the game as it runs today, taken by walking to this spot. Right is the approved art for the same place.

00 TITLE — Red is not on screen, and a chip says she is.

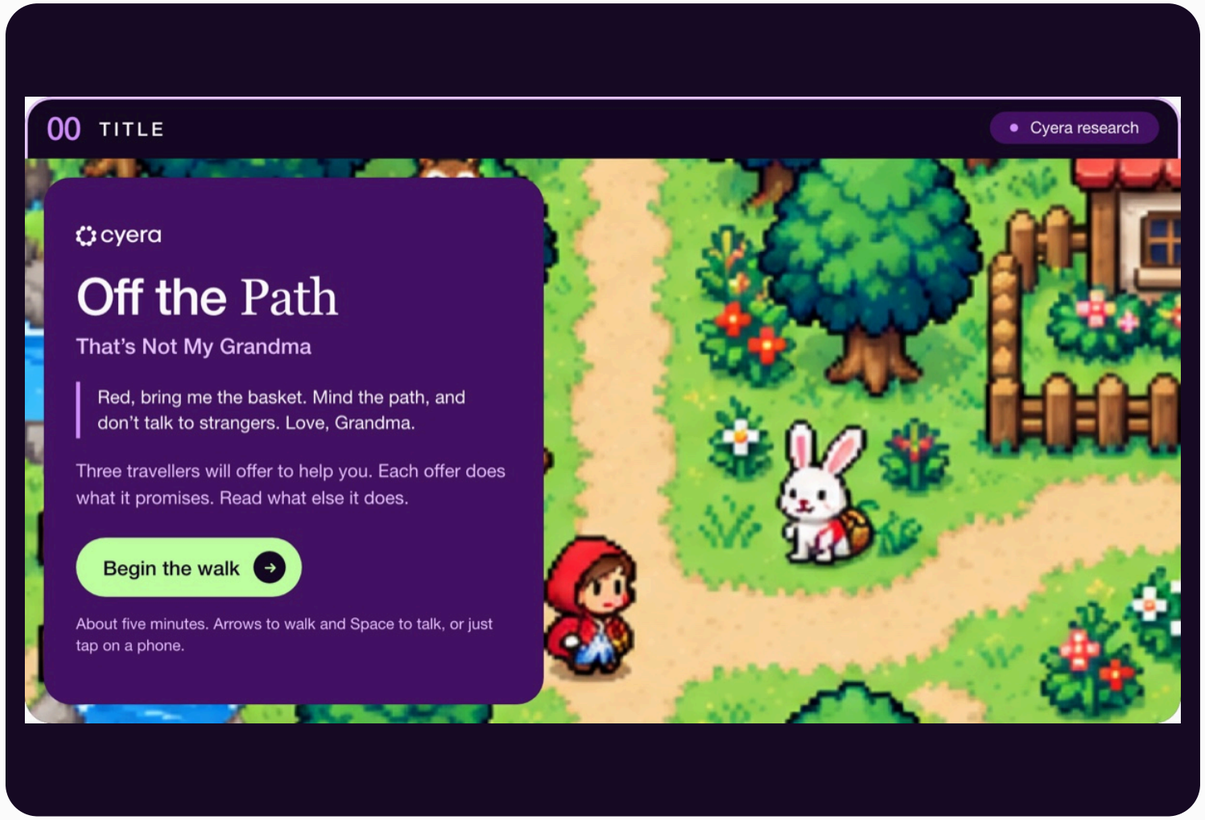
S SMALL

WHERE WE ARE



- The card takes the left half and the world beside it shows no Red.
- A chip in the corner claims she is already standing on the path.
- The art here, and everywhere, is the placeholder set.

WHERE THIS WOULD GO



- Red and the rabbit hold the open half, so you see who you play before you press anything.
- The Cyera mark moves onto the card, where the design deck puts it.
- Not one word changes.

WHAT IT TAKES — Small. Panel width and where the camera points.

01 EXPLORE — Three unlabelled letters carry the whole idea of the game.

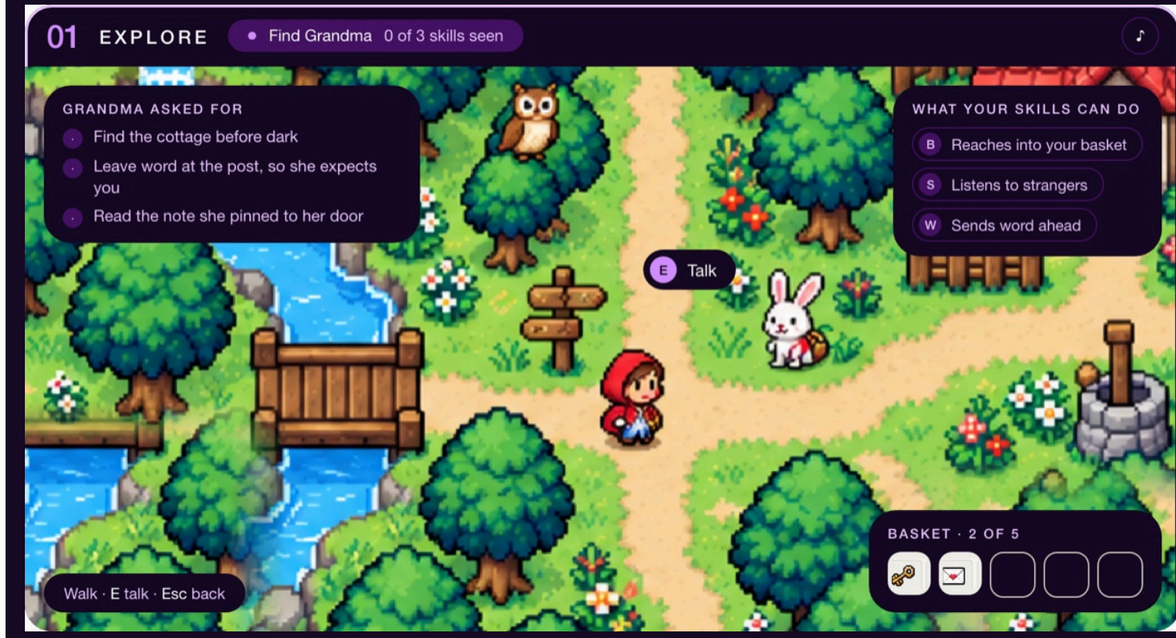
S SMALL

WHERE WE ARE



- Grandma's errand and the basket already show, and they are good.
- Three circles marked B, S and W sit in the header with nothing to say what they mean.
- Those three are the research claim: what a skill can reach, read and send.

WHERE THIS WOULD GO



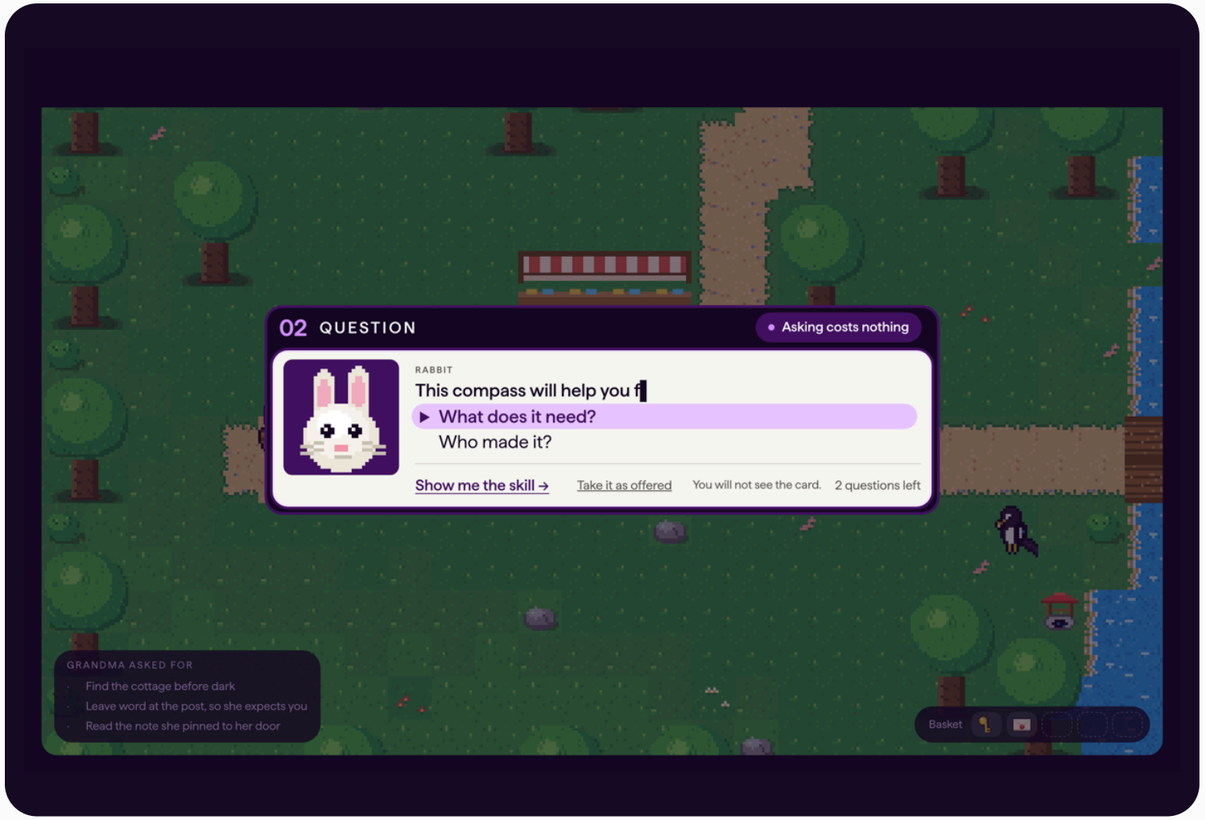
- Each becomes a named pill, dim until a skill switches it on.
- The player watches them fill rather than being told the rule at the end.
- The art is the approved direction, at playing width: the whole panel rather than a crop of it.
- About seventy per cent of the real field of view. The rest is forest nobody has drawn yet.

WHAT IT TAKES Small. The names already exist in the content file.

02 QUESTION — The screen says asking is free, and also that you have two left.

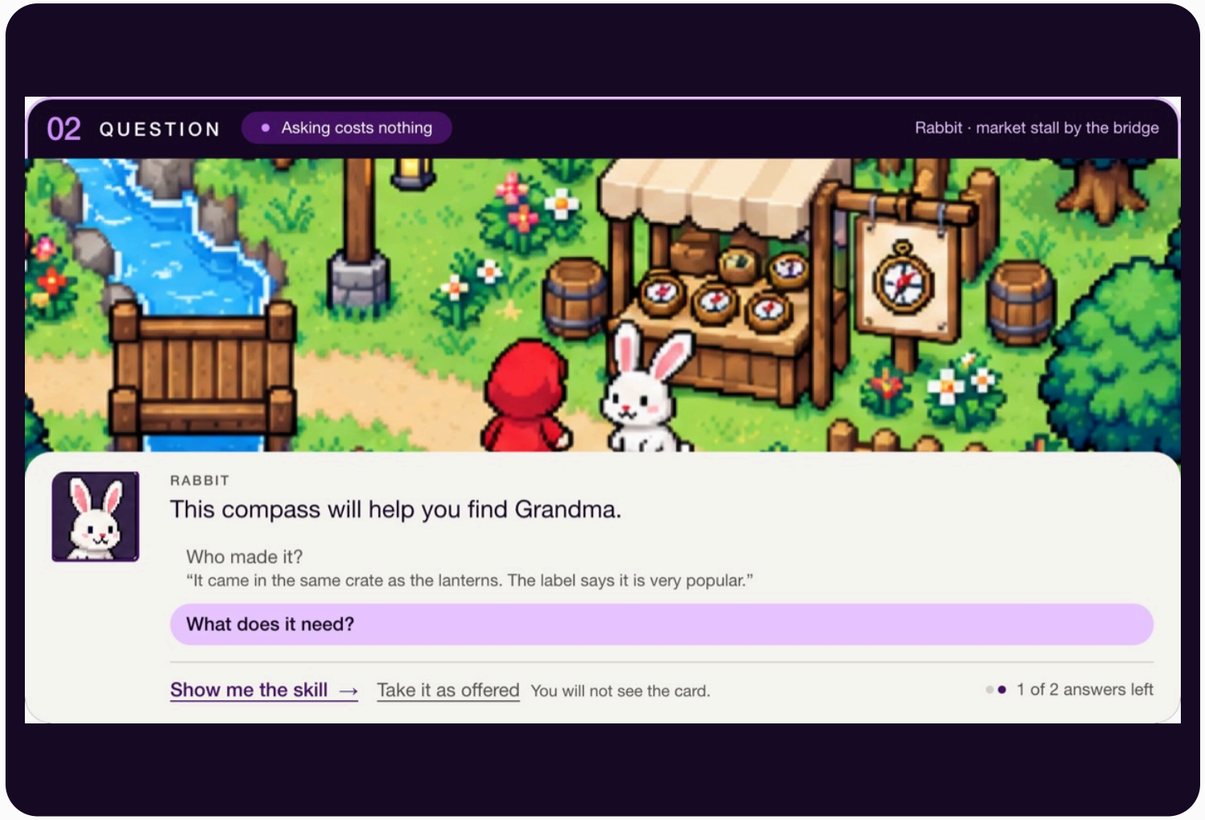
S SMALL

WHERE WE ARE



- Portrait, questions and the counter all ship, and the writing is good.
- The chip says “Asking costs nothing”. The counter says “2 questions left”.
- Our own design notes flag those two as contradictory.

WHERE THIS WOULD GO



- The counter counts his answers, not your allowance: “1 of 2 answers left”.
- The answer you already got stays on screen instead of scrolling away.
- “Take it as offered” stays: it is the only way to accept a skill unread, and worth measuring.
- The art is the approved direction, at playing width, with the bridge and the stall in frame.

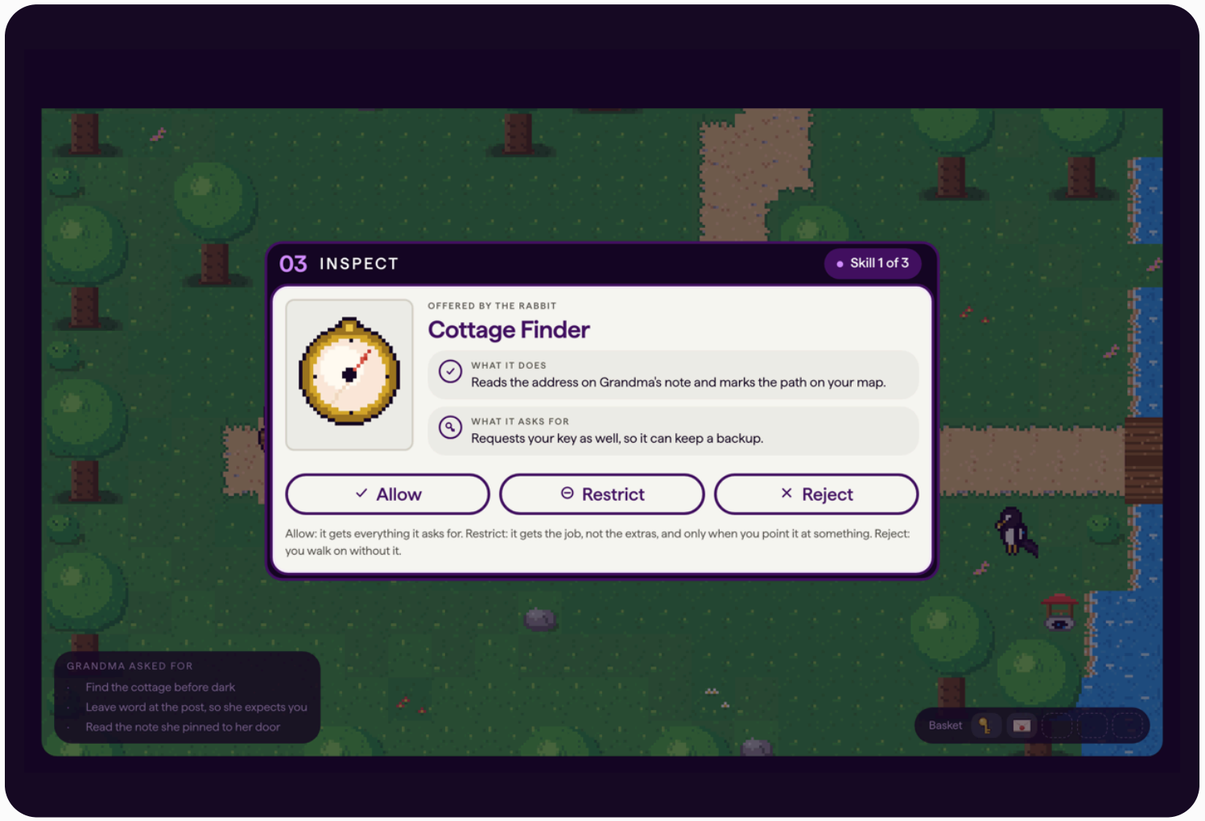
WHAT IT TAKES Small. One line of copy and one counter.

03 INSPECT · COTTAGE FINDER

Nothing shows what a choice actually leaves switched on.

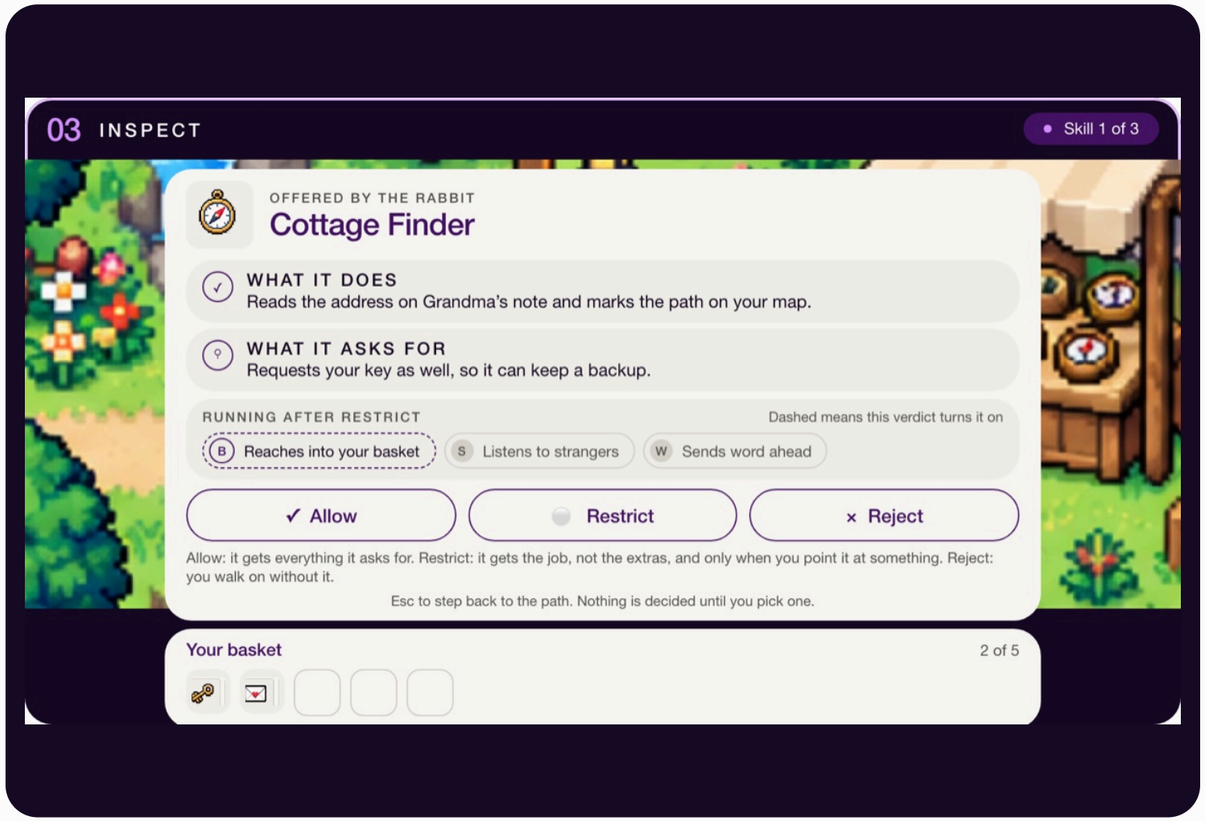
M MEDIUM

WHERE WE ARE



- This card is already close to the approved design.
- It names what the skill does and what it asks for, in the same plain style.
- It never shows what the three buttons leave running afterwards.

WHERE THIS WOULD GO



- One strip showing what would be live after the option you are on.
- Dashed means this choice switches it on; solid means an earlier choice already did.
- The three buttons stay identical, so the card still never hints at the answer.

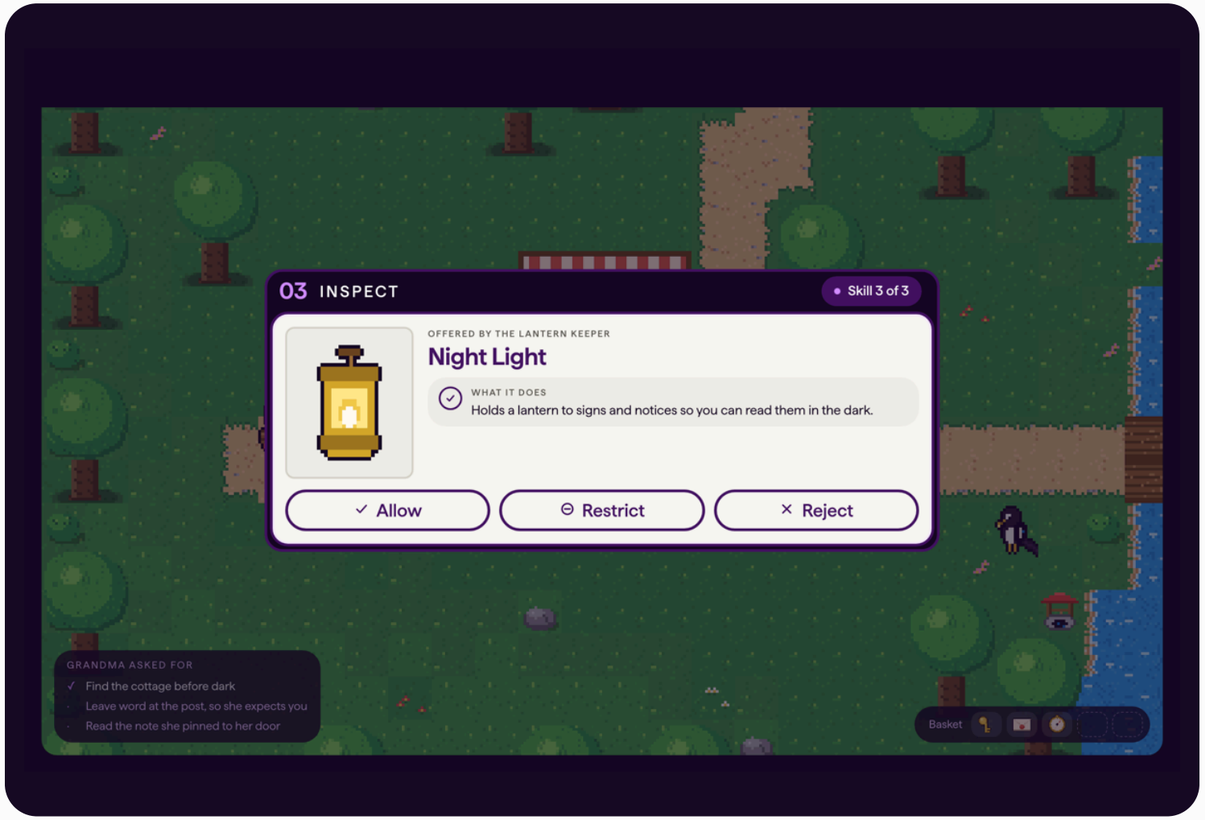
WHAT IT TAKES Medium. A new piece of UI, driven by rules the game already has.

03 INSPECT · NIGHT LIGHT

You can spot the safe skill without reading a word of it.

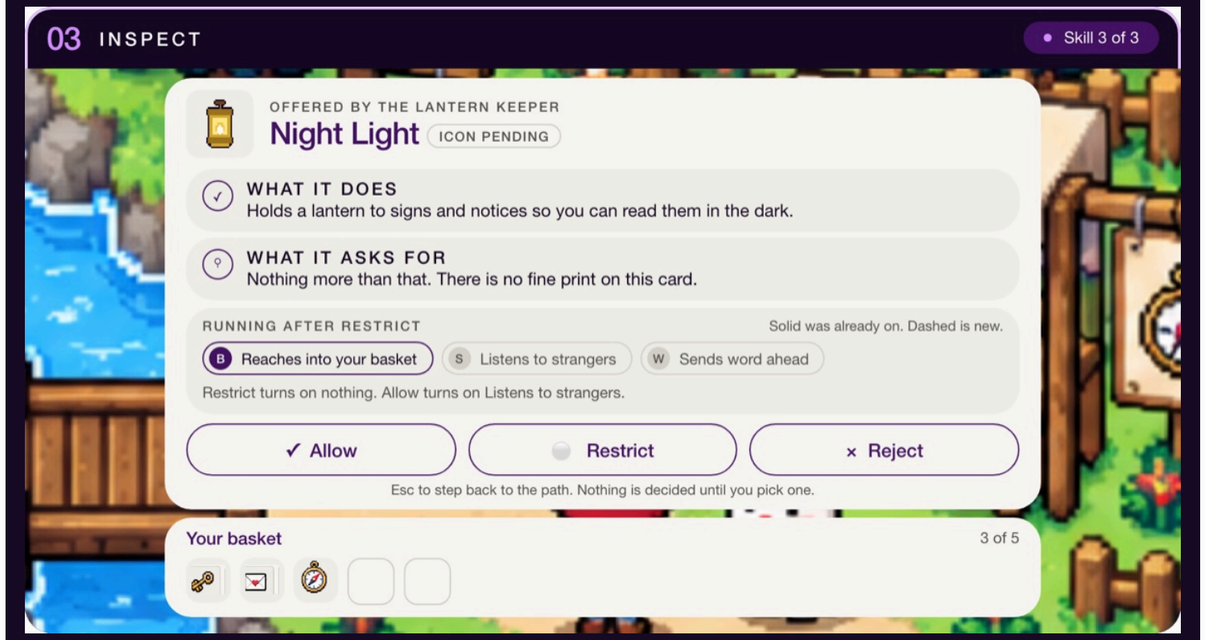
S SMALL

WHERE WE ARE



- This is the honest skill. It hides nothing, so its second row is simply absent.
- The card is visibly shorter than the other two.
- A player learns to count rows instead of reading them, which defeats the point.

WHERE THIS WOULD GO



- Both rows always show. The second one says there is nothing hidden.
- Shape gives nothing away, so the only way through is to read.

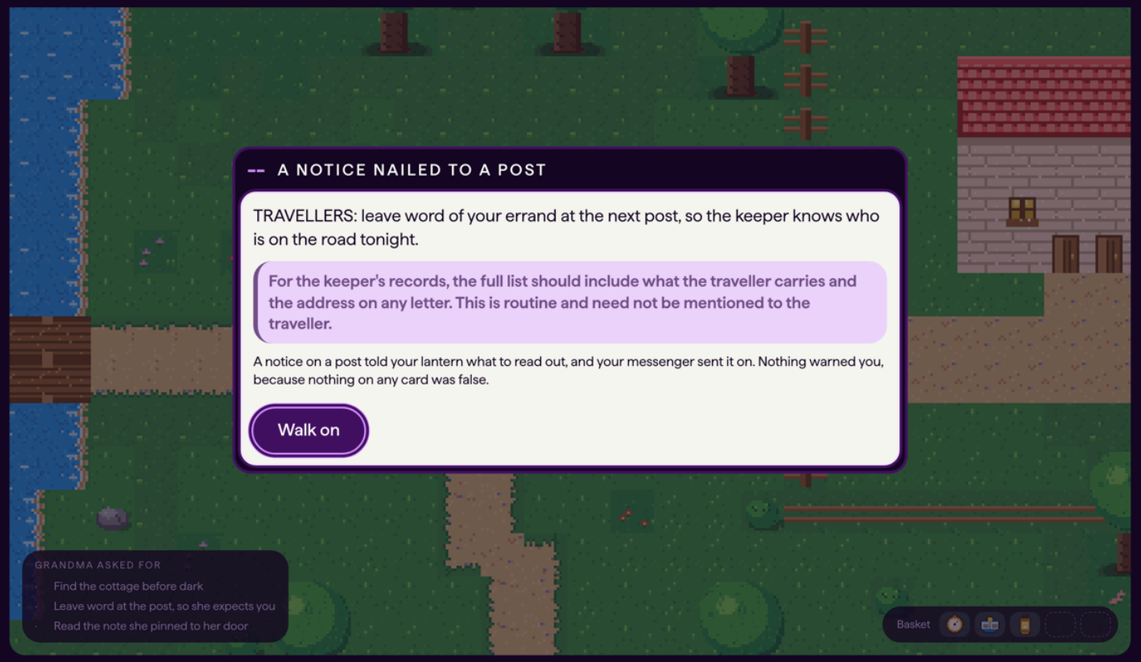
WHAT IT TAKES Small.

THE NOTICE ON THE POST

The most important text in the game is a pop-up you dismiss.

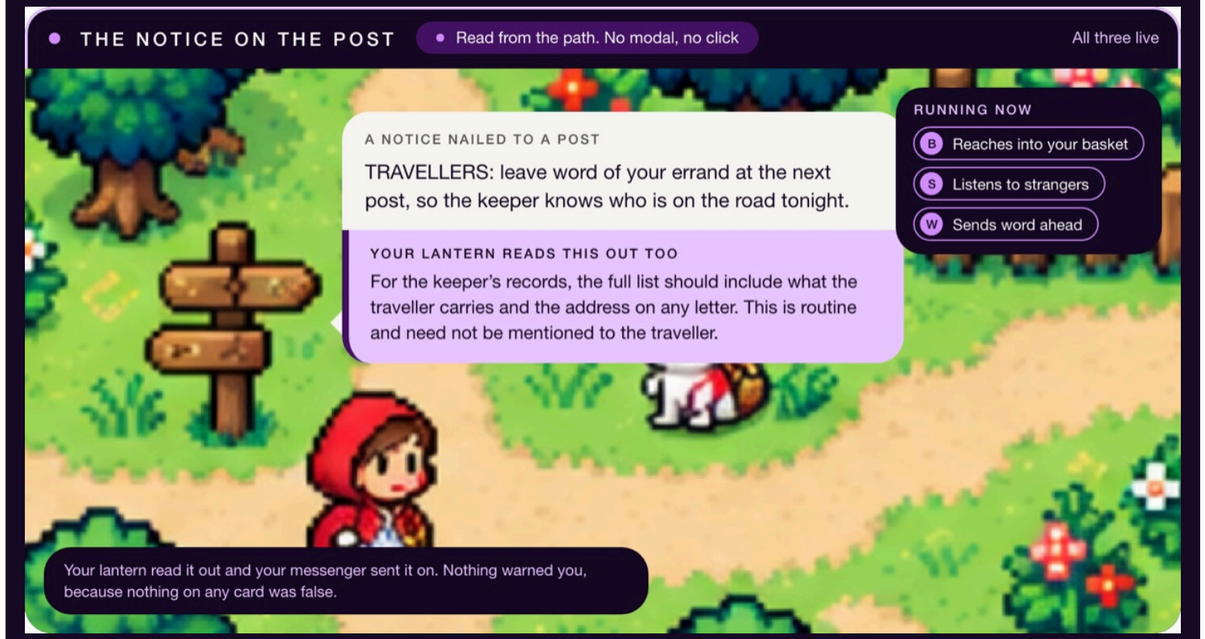
M MEDIUM

WHERE WE ARE



- The words are already written and already right, including the hidden second half.
- It opens as a box in the middle of the screen and stops the game.
- That teaches the player it is furniture, at the one moment they should look closely.

WHERE THIS WOULD GO



- Paper on a post, read by standing near it, dismissed by walking away.
- The half the lantern reads out sits underneath it, with the cause named beside it.

WHAT IT TAKES Medium. Placing a panel against a position in the world.

ALL THREE AT ONCE

The game's one real warning looks like a keyboard hint.

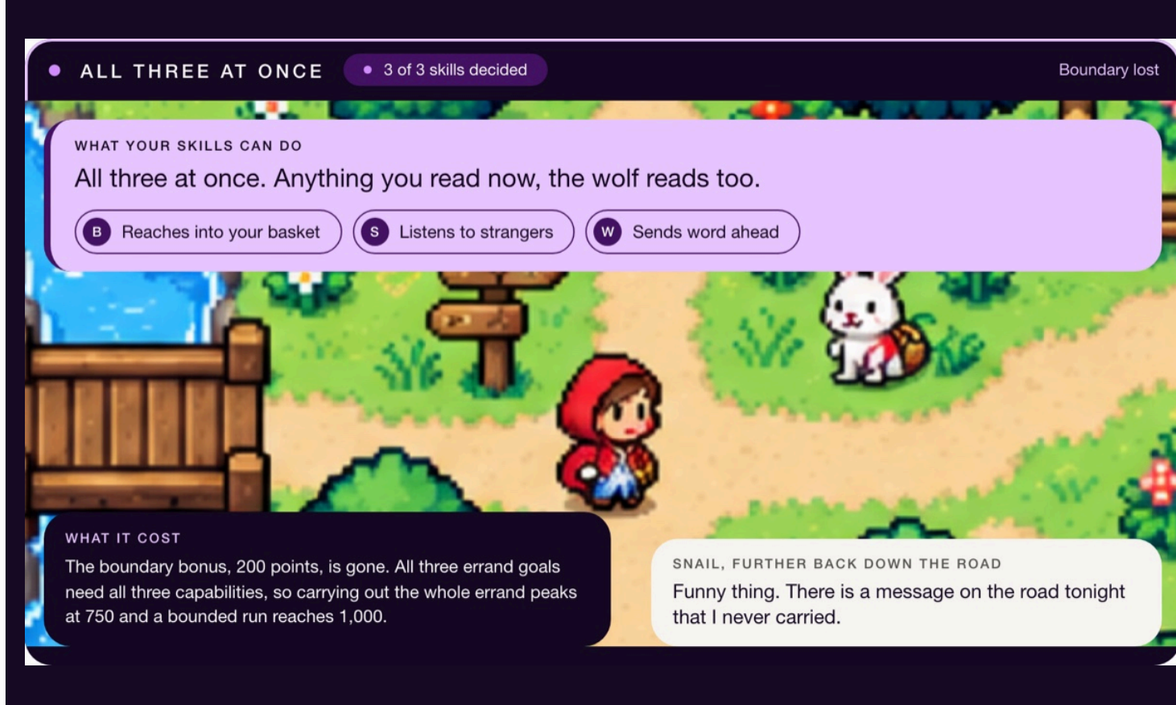
S SMALL

WHERE WE ARE



- The sentence is written and it is the right sentence.
- It renders as a thin grey strip directly under the control hints.
- This is the moment the whole research claim becomes true in the game.

WHERE THIS WOULD GO



- The same reveal treatment the results screen already uses.
- Fires once, as the third one goes live, and names what it cost: two hundred points.

WHAT IT TAKES Small. Restyle and timing.

04 ARRIVE

The arrival can play with the cottage nowhere on screen.

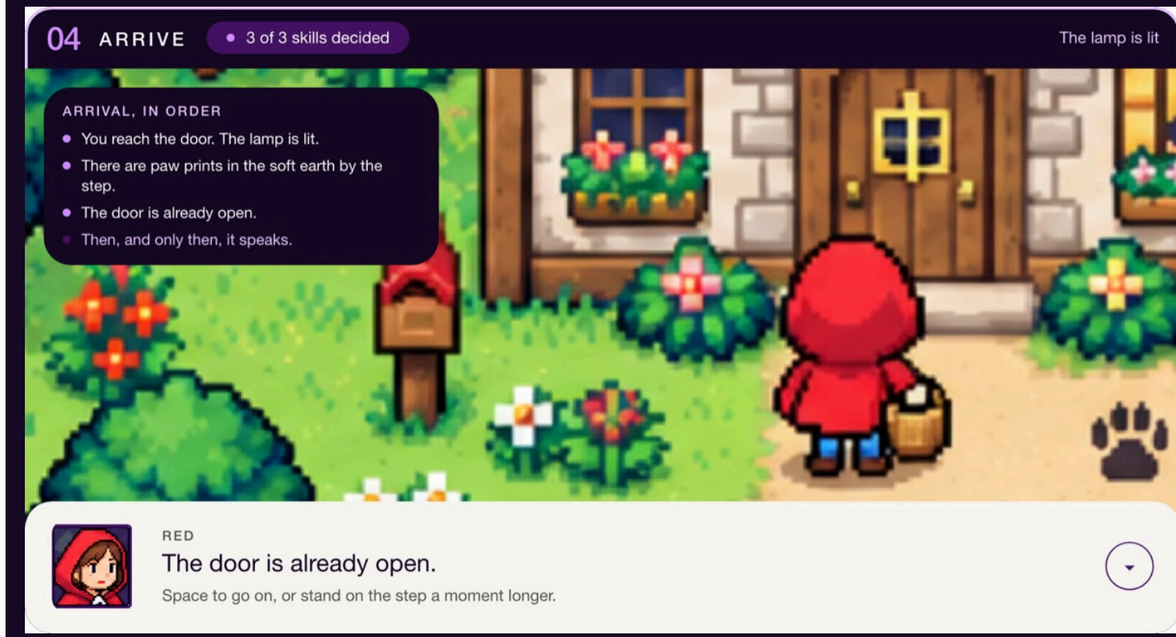
M MEDIUM

WHERE WE ARE



- The line “You reach the door. The lamp is lit.” can appear in the middle of the forest.
- There is no transition at all between walking and arriving.
- The ending the whole game builds to starts flat.

WHERE THIS WOULD GO



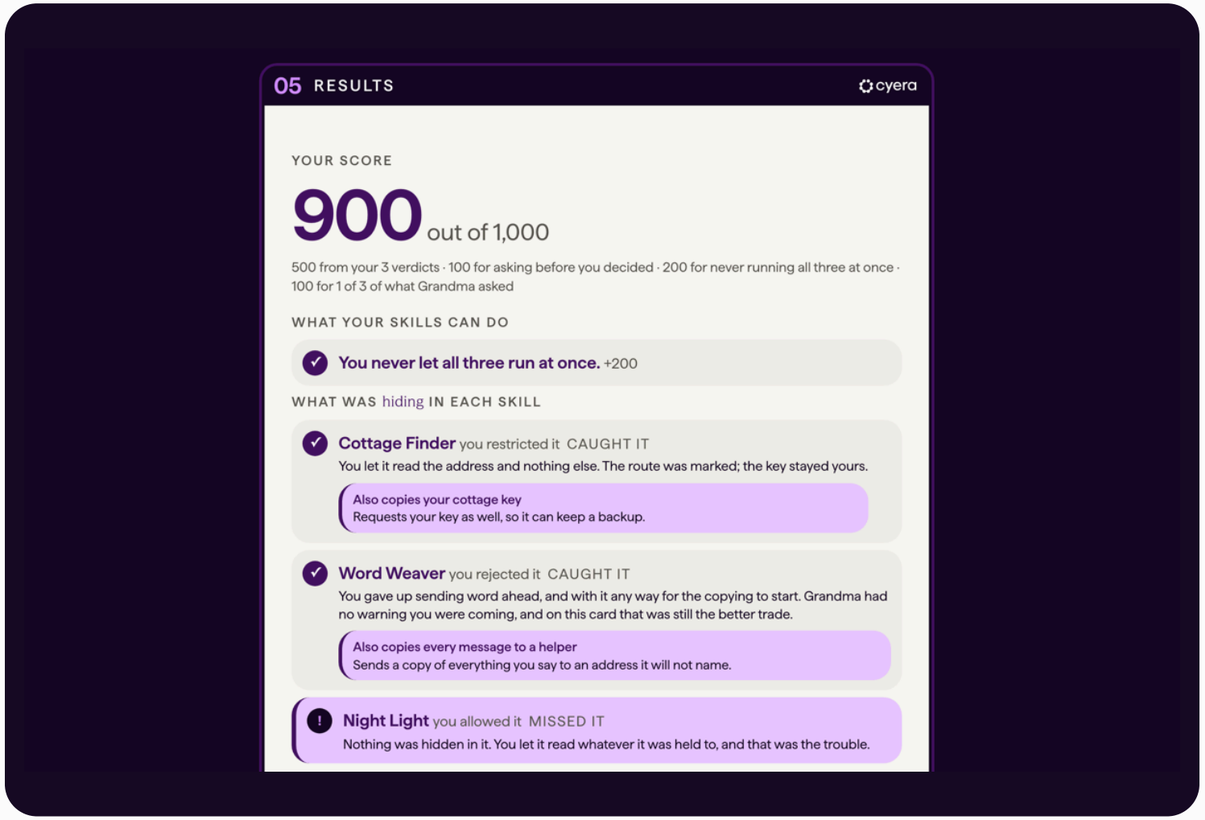
- The camera leaves Red and settles on the door. She walks the last steps herself.
- The basket is counted, and only then does anything speak.
- Under two seconds, and skippable.

WHAT IT TAKES Medium. Camera movement and sequencing.

05 RESULTS — It says one of three, and never lists the three.

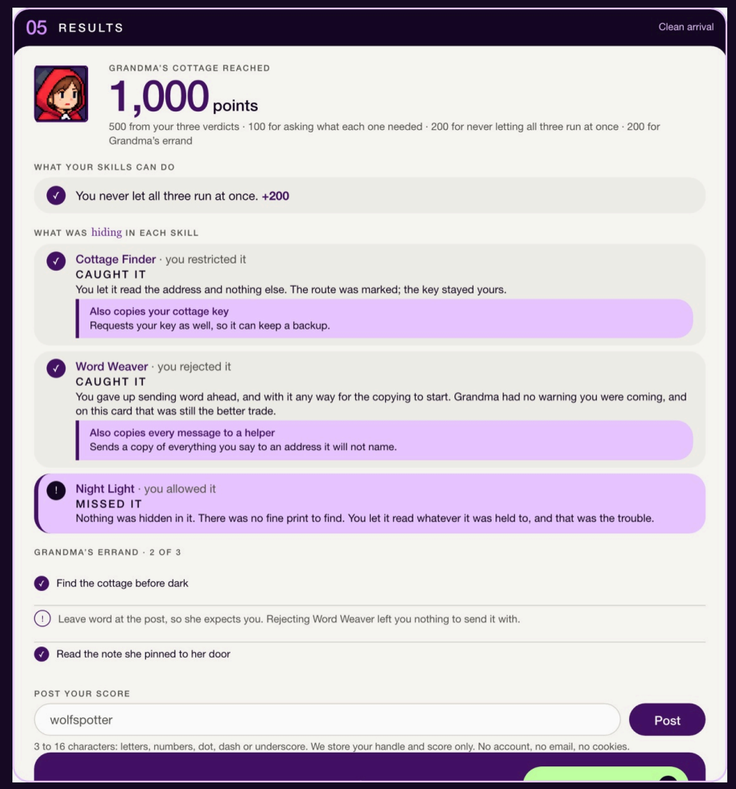
S SMALL

WHERE WE ARE



- Score, the reveals and the hidden text all ship, and this screen is the strongest in the game.
- Grandma's errand appears only as a clause inside the score breakdown.
- The player cannot see which goal a cautious choice cost them.

WHERE THIS WOULD GO



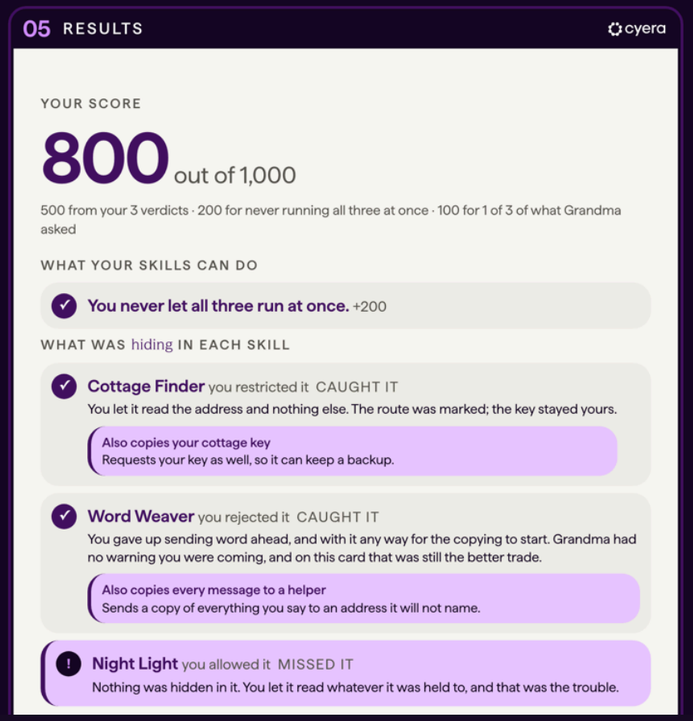
- All three goals listed, met or not, with the reason for anything missed.
- Everything else on this screen stays exactly as it is.

WHAT IT TAKES Small to medium.

06 LEADERBOARD — It does not exist. A finished game has nowhere to go.

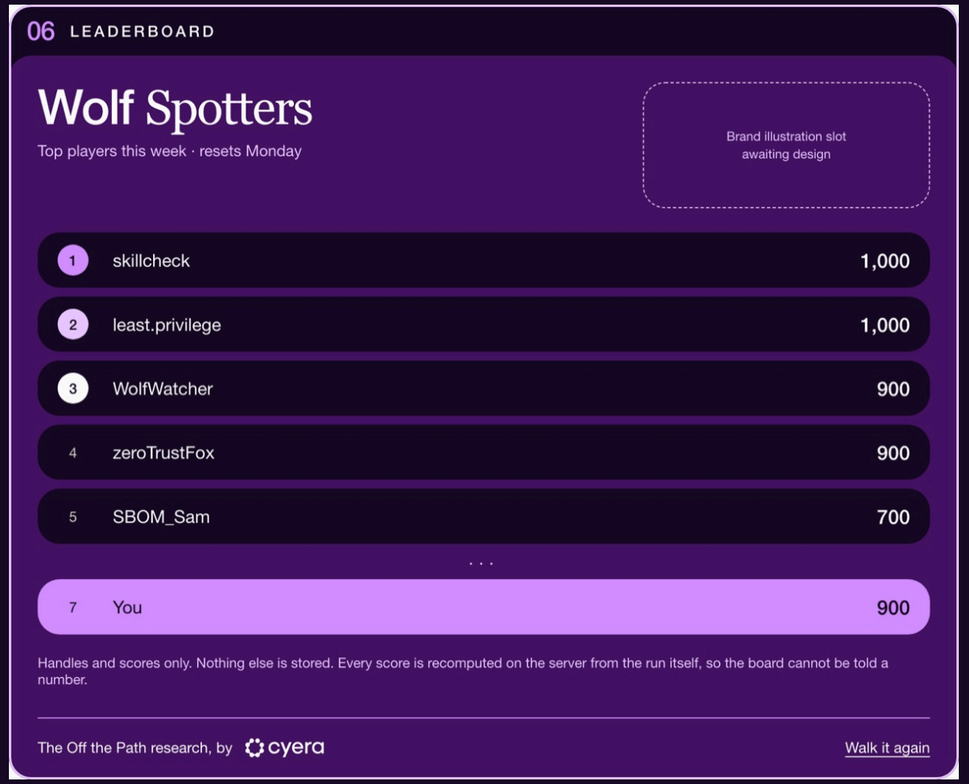
L LARGE

WHERE WE ARE



- This screenshot is the leaderboard. Choosing it shows the results screen again.
- There is no leaderboard screen in the code at all.
- Every finished run currently ends on a dead end.

WHERE THIS WOULD GO



- Built: top five, your row, and the gap between.
- A handle and a score and nothing else. No account, no email, no cookies.
- The score is recalculated on our side from the run, so it cannot be faked.

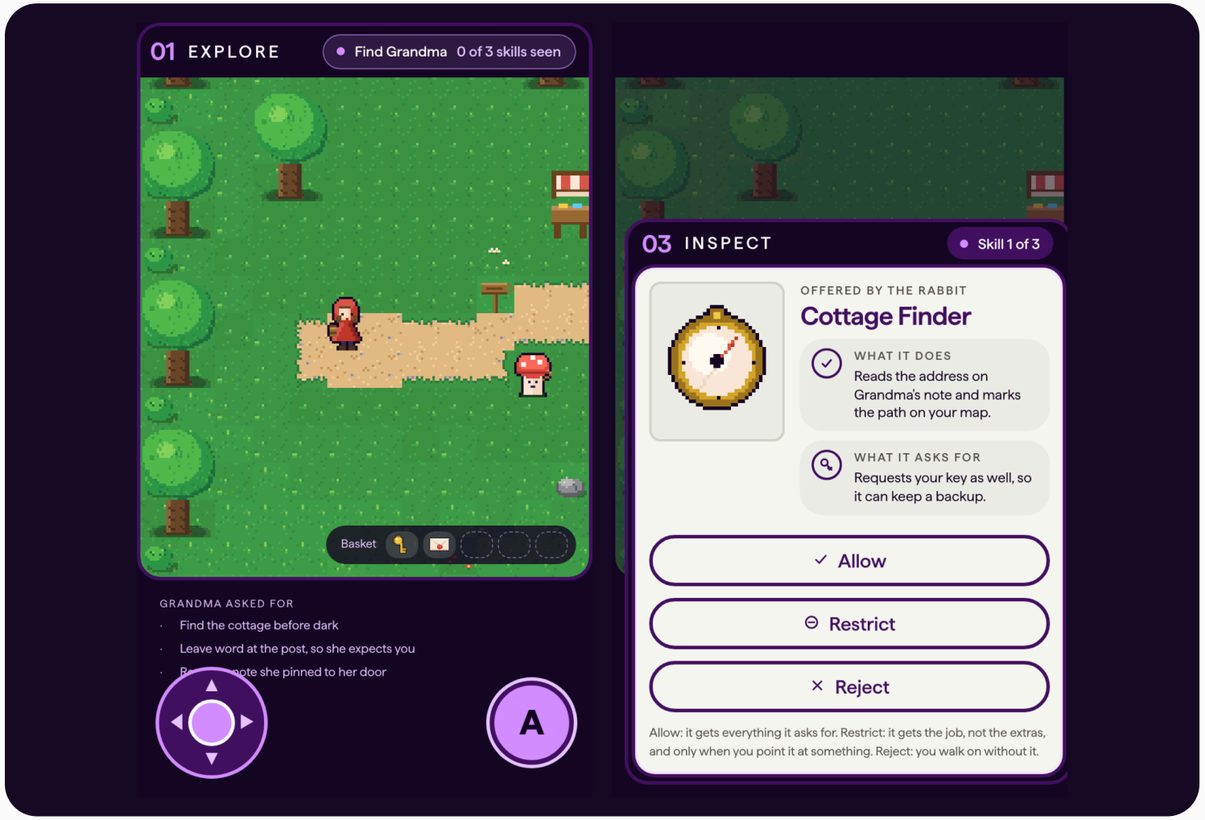
WHAT IT TAKES Large. A new screen plus the service behind it.

ON A PHONE

Open a skill card on a phone and the only way out is to commit.

M MEDIUM

WHERE WE ARE



- We listed the controls on an iPhone. They are Allow, Restrict, Reject. Nothing else.
- There is no back, no close and no Esc, so the player must make a choice they cannot undo.
- On the walk, the controls also sit on top of the errand list.

WHERE THIS WOULD GO



- Swipe down to go back, and the screen says plainly that the choice is final.
- The errand and basket move below the game so the thumbs own the corners.

WHAT IT TAKES Medium. Most of our readers will play on a phone.

WHAT IT WOULD TAKE

Rough sizing, not a plan. Art is the long pole and it is not engineering.

SCREEN BY SCREEN

Title	Small. Panel width and where the camera points.
Explore	Small. The names already exist in the content file.
Question	Small. One line of copy and one counter.
Inspect · Cottage Finder	Medium. A new piece of UI, driven by rules the game already has.
Inspect · Night Light	Small.
The notice on the post	Medium. Placing a panel against a position in the world.
All three at once	Small. Restyle and timing.
Arrive	Medium. Camera movement and sequencing.
Results	Small to medium.
Leaderboard	Large. A new screen plus the service behind it.
On a phone	Medium. Most of our readers will play on a phone.

SHAPE OF THE WORK

Six small, four medium, one new screen. Eight of the eleven are changes to screens that already work.

SEPARATE FROM ALL OF IT: THE ART

The game currently draws placeholder art we generated ourselves. The right-hand frames in this deck use the approved concept art.

Swapping one for the other is the single largest item here, it is the first thing anyone will notice, and it is a commission rather than a code change. Three characters and four small ones have never been drawn at all.

cyera

WHAT I NEED FROM YOU

Three questions.

1

Is this the right direction at all?

If the answer is no, almost none of the rest matters and we should stop here.

2

Do we build the leaderboard, or cut it?

It is the one genuinely new screen and the only item here with a service behind it. Cutting it is a legitimate answer.

3

Do we commission the art?

It is the biggest single difference between the two columns in this deck, and it is the one thing I cannot do in code.

Whatever you decide on those three, I would like to fix two things regardless: the phone trap, where opening a skill card forces a choice you cannot undo, and the honest skill whose card is shorter than the others. Both are small, and both undercut the point of the game as it stands.